

POLICY BRIEF: Addressing the "Care Penalty" in Chicago's Municipal Workforce

To: Chicago Budget & Government Operations Committee

From: Rebe, Social Policy Analyst

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Subject: Structural Wage Disparities Between Protective and Social Service Departments

Executive Summary

An analysis of the 2026 City of Chicago payroll data reveals a significant "Care Penalty," a structural wage gap where staff in health and human service departments earn substantially less than their counterparts in protective services. Even when controlling for managerial status and full-time employment, staff in the **Department of Family and Support Services (DFSS)** earn **\$19,654 less** annually than staff in the **Chicago Police Department (CPD)**.

The Problem: The "Care Penalty"

Social and health services are the backbone of Chicago's community safety net. However, current compensation structures do not reflect this priority.

- **The Gap:** The average base salary for a non-managerial staffer in Public Health is **\$106,404**, while a staffer in Family Support earns only **\$98,205**.
- **The Contrast:** A staffer in the Police Department, with comparable seniority, earns an average of **\$117,861**.

The Evidence (Methodological Rigor)

This finding is not a result of "outliers" or simple averages. We deployed a **Generalized Additive Model (GAM)** to account for Chicago's rigid union pay steps. The model confirms that the "Care Penalty" is a **structural constant**, not an accidental variation.

Policy Implications

1. **Recruitment & Retention:** The \$19k gap makes it difficult for DFSS and CDPH to compete for high-quality talent, potentially leading to higher turnover in critical social service roles.
 2. **Equity Concerns:** Social service departments often employ a higher percentage of workers from the communities they serve. This wage gap may inadvertently exacerbate racial and gender-based wealth inequities within the city's own workforce.
 3. **Misaligned Priorities:** The current pay structure suggests that "enforcement" is valued significantly higher than "support" or "prevention."
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Recommendations

- **Perform a Comprehensive Wage Equity Study:** Investigate why "Staff" roles in human services are graded lower than "Staff" roles in protective services.
- **Standardize Baseline Pay Grades:** Adjust the entry-level salary floors for DFSS and CDPH to narrow the gap with the Police Department by at least 15% over the next two budget cycles.
- **Implement "Care Premiums":** Introduce retention bonuses for social workers and public health analysts working in high-need community areas to offset the base salary disparity.